STUDY AID · MATTHEW 25:31-26:2 · EPISODE 49 (#52 OF 58 IN THE PLAYLIST)

The Least *of These*

Sheep looking for sheep

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 25:31-26:2 in the LSB | 28:58 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: 'The Least of These' Is NOT What You Think. Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT · ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 25:31-26:2. The Son of Man sits on His glorious throne, gathers the nations and separates them as a shepherd separates sheep from goats. Those on His right fed, welcomed, clothed and visited Him; those on His left did not. 'To the extent that you did it to one of these brothers of Mine, even the least of them, you did it to Me.' Then Jesus says that after two days the Passover is coming and the Son of Man will be handed over for crucifixion.
- Everything here stands on Jesus' earlier teaching: the coming of the Son of Man (10:23; 16:27-28; 19:28; five times in chapter 24), the little ones (10:42; 18:6, 10, 14) and His brothers (12:50). So 'the least of these My brothers' is a specific group: Jesus' disciples.
- Jesus sent His disciples as sheep among wolves to the lost sheep of Israel (10:6, 16), told them to stay with whoever welcomed them (10:11-14), and modeled the search with words and deeds: feeding, healing, freeing the oppressed (10:8).
- The sheep and goats come from Ezekiel 34: God indicts the shepherds who fed themselves, promises to seek His own sheep, and will 'judge between one sheep and another, between the rams and the male goats' (34:17). Biblical judgment, like the judges (shophetim) who saved Israel, is both punitive and restorative: a remnant is saved.
- The lesson: when Jesus comes in His glory, He expects to find His disciples among the lost, proclaiming the

> *"When Jesus comes in his glory, he expects to find his disciples among the lost proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom of heaven with both their words and their lifestyles.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"The least of these, that specific phrase, it refers to a specific group of people. It's the disciples of Jesus.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

gospel of the kingdom of heaven with both their words and their lifestyles. It is not the sheep's job to separate from the goats; the sheep go find other lost sheep among them.

Let earlier teaching define the words

Before deciding what a phrase means, find where the same speaker used it before. Jesus' own words in Matthew 10, 12 and 18 shape 'the least of these My brothers.'

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB. This is Episode 49 of the Matthew study (playlist item 52).

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 25:31-26:2 and turns to Matthew 7, 10, 12, 13 and 18, Ezekiel 34 and Judges. Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 25:31-46
Read in full: the sheep and the goats.

Matthew 26:1-2
After two days, the Passover.

Matthew 10:5-16
Sheep sent to the lost sheep.

Matthew 10:40-42
A cup of cold water to a little one.

Matthew 12:46-50
My brother and sister and mother.

Matthew 18:1-14
The little ones and the lost sheep.

Matthew 13:24-30
Wheat and tares grow together.

Matthew 13:47-50
The net and the separation.

Matthew 7:15-23
Wolves in sheep's clothing.

Ezekiel 34:1-24
The shepherds of Israel; God judges between sheep and sheep.

Judges 2:16-18
Yahweh raised up judges who saved them.

Judges 6:11-14
Gideon's call.

Key verses in the LSB

“Truly I say to you, to the extent that you did it to one of these brothers of Mine, even the least of them, you did it to Me.”

Matthew 25:40 (LSB)

“For whoever does the will of My Father who is in heaven, he is My brother and sister and mother.”

Matthew 12:50 (LSB)

“For thus says Lord Yahweh, “Behold, I Myself will seek My sheep and care for them.”

Ezekiel 34:11 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

The least of these

The King, His brothers, and sheep sent to find sheep.

MATTHEW 25:31-36

The King on His throne

MATTHEW 25:31-33 (LSB)

GATHERED

““But when the Son of Man comes in His glory, and all the angels with Him, then He will sit on His glorious throne. And all the nations will be gathered before Him; and He will separate them from one another, as the shepherd separates the sheep from the goats; and he will put the sheep on His right, and the goats on the left.”

FROM THE VIDEO The coming of the Son of Man was already taught in 10:23, 16:27-28 and 19:28, and five times in chapter 24 (verses 27, 30, 37, 39, 44). Chapter 25:31 stands on that foundation. Matthew 10:23 Matthew 19:28

FROM THE VIDEO The separating also echoes the wheat and tares (13:30) and the net (13:49-50). Matthew 13:30 Matthew 13:49-50

◆ Factbook: Son of Man ◆ Factbook: Angel ◆ Factbook: Judgment

MATTHEW 25:40; 10:42; 12:50

The least of these My brothers

THE KING · MATTHEW 25:40

“And the King will answer and say to them, ‘Truly I say to you, to the extent that you did it to one of these brothers of Mine, even the least of them, you did it to Me.’”

JESUS, EARLIER · MATTHEW 10:42

“And whoever in the name of a disciple gives to one of these little ones even a cup of cold water to drink, truly I say to you, he shall not lose his reward.””

FROM THE VIDEO 'Least' is the superlative of the adjective 'little,' which Jesus used for His little ones, His disciples (18:6, 10, 14; see 11:11). Matthew 18:6 Matthew 11:11

FROM THE VIDEO 'My brothers' points the same way: 'whoever does the will of My Father who is in heaven, he is My brother and sister and mother' (12:50). Matthew 12:50

◆ Factbook: Disciples

MATTHEW 10:6, 16; 18:12-14

Sheep sent to find sheep

THE MISSION · MATTHEW 10:16

""Behold, I send you out as sheep in the midst of wolves; so be shrewd as serpents and innocent as doves."

THE LOST ONE · MATTHEW 18:14

"In this way, it is not the will of your Father who is in heaven that one of these little ones perish."

FROM THE VIDEO False prophets come in sheep's clothing but are ravenous wolves (7:15); the disciples are real sheep sent 'to the lost sheep of the house of Israel' (10:6). Matthew 7:15 Matthew 10:6

FROM THE VIDEO Who welcomes the disciples into their home, with food and care, decides whom they stay with (10:11-14). Jesus modeled words and deeds together, and sent them to do the same (10:8). Matthew 10:8 Matthew 10:11-14

◆ Factbook: Hypocrite ◆ Factbook: Shepherd



As the shepherd separates the sheep from the goats

Christ Separating the Sheep from the Goats, mosaic, early 6th century. Sant'Apollinare Nuovo, Ravenna, via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *"The least of these, that specific phrase, it refers to a specific group of people. It's the disciples of Jesus.*
>
> From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

Ezekiel 34

Corrupt shepherds, a seeking God, rams and male goats.



EZEKIEL 34:8-10

Shepherds who fed themselves

EZEKIEL 34:10 (LSB)

INDICTMENT

"“Thus says Lord Yahweh, “Behold, I am against the shepherds, and I will seek My flock from their hand and make them cease from shepherding the flock. So the shepherds will not shepherd themselves anymore, but I will deliver My flock from their mouth so that they will not be food for them.”””

FROM THE VIDEO Ezekiel 34 is God's indictment of the corrupt shepherds, the leaders of Israel. Jesus has alluded to it before, and the separating of sheep and goats in 25:32 comes straight out of it.

◆ Factbook: Ezekiel (prophet) ◆ Factbook: Shepherd



EZEKIEL 34:11-16

I Myself will seek My sheep

EZEKIEL 34:11-12 (LSB)

PROMISE

“For thus says Lord Yahweh, “Behold, I Myself will seek My sheep and care for them. As a shepherd cares for his herd in the day when he is among his sheep which are spread out, so I will care for My sheep and will deliver them from all the places to which they were scattered on a cloudy and gloomy day.”

FROM THE VIDEO Since the Lord can no longer rely on His corrupt shepherds, He will search for His lost sheep, feed and shelter them, and bring them into their own land. The video urges reading all of Ezekiel 34.



EZEKIEL 34:17

Rams and male goats

EZEKIEL 34:17 (LSB)

SEPARATION

“"As for you, My flock, thus says Lord Yahweh, ‘Behold, I will judge between one sheep and another, between the rams and the male goats.”

FROM THE VIDEO The Lord warns His gathered flock not to become like the corrupt shepherds of old. A ram is an adult male sheep: God is separating sheep from goats.

FROM THE VIDEO The disciples are the true living temple, new priests keeping God's presence with His people, and sheep looking for the Lord's other lost sheep.

◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish) ◆ Factbook: Priest

> *“It's not the sheep's job to separate from the goats.*
>
> From the video

Judgment that saves

The judges, a remnant, and the gospel in word and deed.

JUDGES 2:16

Judges who saved

⚖️ JUDGES 2:16 (LSB)

SHOPHET

“Then Yahweh raised up judges who saved them from the hands of those who plundered them.”

FROM THE VIDEO The Hebrew for 'judge' (shophet) comes from a root meaning to judge, govern or vindicate. The judges were more accurately deliverers: they saved Israel from enemies, kept peace, gave impartial justice and protected widows and orphans.

FROM THE VIDEO Gideon destroyed the Midianites and freed Israel; see also Samson, Othniel, Ehud and Deborah. **Judges 6:11-14**

◆ Factbook: Gideon ◆ Factbook: Judgment

2 KINGS 25; 2 CHRONICLES 36

Destruction and a remnant

🔥 2 KINGS 25:9 (LSB)

BOTH AT ONCE

“And he burned the house of Yahweh, the king’s house, and all the houses of Jerusalem; even every great house he burned with fire.”

FROM THE VIDEO Biblical judgment is punitive and restorative at once. Babylon's campaign was a horror, yet Daniel, Shadrach, Meshach, Abednego and Ezekiel thrived in the midst of destruction and exile. **2 Chronicles 36:17-20**

FROM THE VIDEO Judgment is coming to Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70, but a remnant will be saved. The difference tracks along who accepts Jesus' teaching and who rejects it.

◆ Factbook: Remnant ◆ Factbook: Babylon ◆ Factbook: Daniel (the prophet)

MATTHEW 25:35-36, 46

Words and lifestyle

🍞 MATTHEW 25:35-36 (LSB)

THE LESSON

“For I was hungry, and you gave Me something to eat; I was thirsty, and you gave Me something to drink; I was a stranger, and you invited Me in; naked, and you clothed Me; I was sick, and you visited Me; I was in prison, and you came to Me.’”

FROM THE VIDEO For first-century Jews it made no sense to disconnect action from words. Westerners tend to reduce the gospel to propositions recited aloud; the gospel is more.

FROM THE VIDEO Access to God's presence will no longer be in one place but in the hearts of His new priests, His disciples, spreading His temple around the world.

BACKGROUND 'These will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life' (25:46). **Matthew 25:46**

◆ Factbook: Gospel ◆ Factbook: Eternal life



Into eternal life

Fra Angelico, The Last Judgement, c. 1431. Via Wikimedia Commons (Web Gallery of Art), public domain

> *Did you know that judgment properly defined by the Bible contains both concepts of destruction and salvation at the same time?*
>
> From the video

06

Who's who in 25:31-26:2

What the video says, then a short background note.

The Son of Man, the King

VIDEO Sits on His glorious throne and separates the nations.

BACKGROUND Daniel 7:13-14 pictures one like a son of man given dominion and a kingdom.

Matthew 25:31-34 | Daniel 7:13-14 | ◆ Son of Man

The sheep and the goats

VIDEO Two kinds of people: His disciples and those who reject Him.

BACKGROUND Ezekiel 34:17 already pictures God judging 'between the rams and the male goats.'

Ezekiel 34:17 | ◆ Shepherd | ◆ Parable of the sheep and goats

The least of these My brothers

VIDEO Jesus' disciples, His little ones.

BACKGROUND Interpreters debate this; see the debate box.

Matthew 25:40 | Matthew 12:50 | ◆ Disciples

Gideon

VIDEO A judge who destroyed the Midianites and freed Israel.

BACKGROUND Called at the wine press in Ophrah (Judges 6:11).

Judges 6:11-14 | ◆ Gideon | ◆ Midianites

Daniel and his friends

VIDEO Faithful ones who thrived in exile.

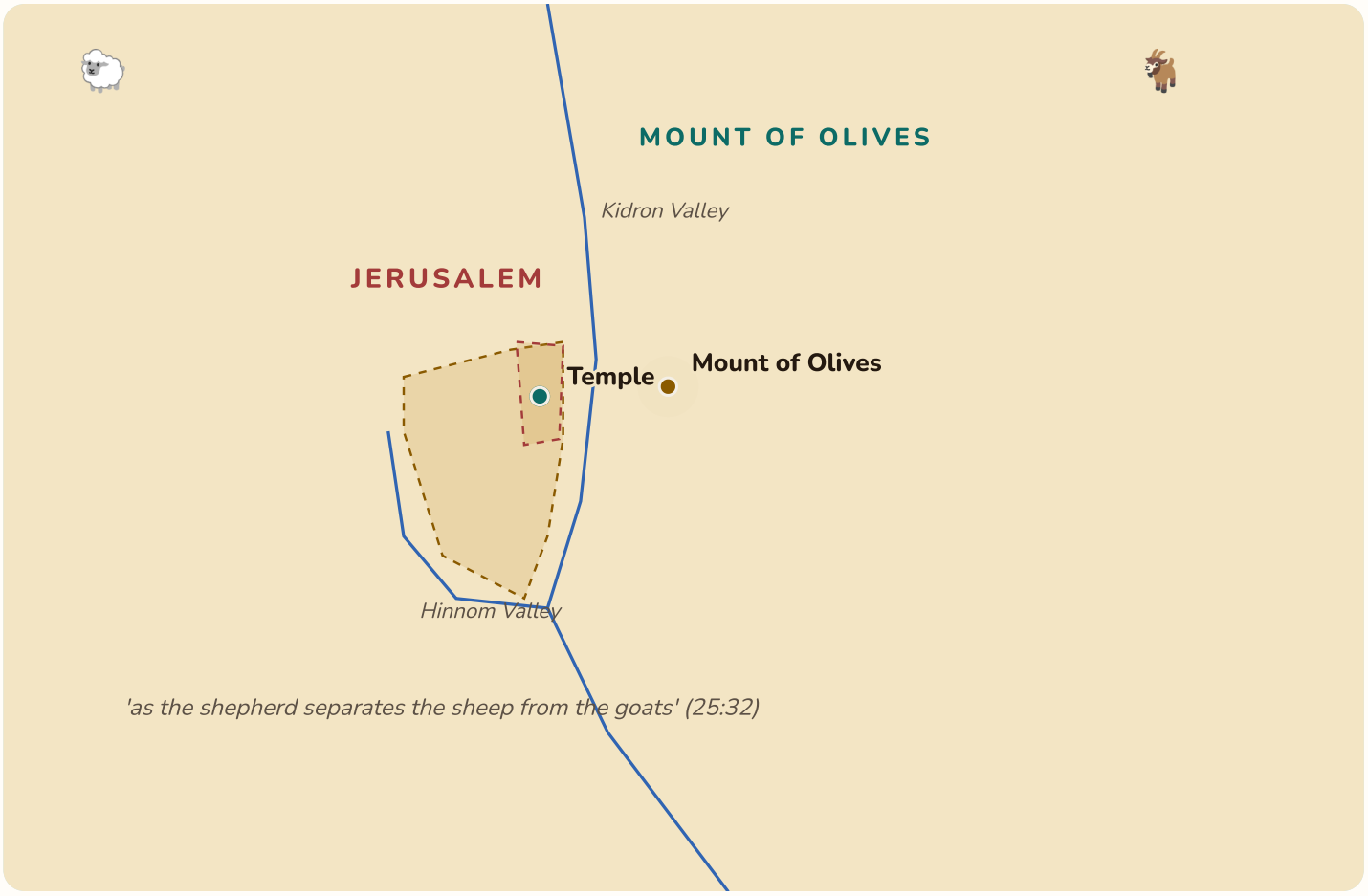
BACKGROUND Taken to Babylon in the first deportation (Daniel 1:1-7).

Daniel 1:1-7 | ◆ Daniel (the prophet) | ◆ Babylon | ◆ Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego

07 · BACKGROUND

Where the discourse ends

The pin outlined in the video's color is a place the video points to. Gold pins are background.



● Named in the video ● Background

Schematic: drawn for this study from known sites. Walls (gold dashes) and the temple platform (coral dashes) are approximate for the first century.

Temple VIDEO

Its coming fall frames the whole discourse on judgment (24:2).

◆ Factbook: Temple (Jewish)

Mount of Olives BACKGROUND

Where Jesus ends the discourse (24:3); two days before the Passover (26:2).

◆ Factbook: Mount of Olives

Key terms

The least of these

VIDEO

In the video's reading, Jesus' disciples, His 'little ones.'

◆ Factbook: Disciples

Brothers

VIDEO

Jesus' spiritual family: whoever does the Father's will (12:50).

Shepherd

VIDEO

A leader of God's people; Ezekiel 34 indicts the corrupt ones.

◆ Factbook: Shepherd

Judge (shophet)

VIDEO

One who judges, governs and delivers; the judges were saviors.

◆ Factbook: Judgment

Remnant

VIDEO

The faithful who are saved through God's judgment.

◆ Factbook: Remnant

Hospitality

VIDEO

Welcoming, feeding and caring for strangers, here Jesus' sent ones.

◆ Factbook: Hospitality

09 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

πρόβατον

probaton G4263

Sheep.

Greek · Matt 25:32

ἔριφος

eriphos G2056

Kid, young goat.

Greek · Matt 25:32

ἀφορίζω

aphorizō G873

To separate, set apart.

Greek · Matt 25:32

ἐλάχιστος

elachistos G1646

Least, smallest (superlative of 'little').

Greek · Matt 25:40

ἀδελφός

ξένος

adelphos `G80`

Brother; fellow member of a family or community.

Greek · Matt 25:40

xenos `G3581`

Stranger, foreigner; also host.

Greek · Matt 25:35

◆ Factbook: Hospitality

κόλασις

kolasis `G2851`

Punishment. Look up: BDAG, κόλασις.

Greek · Matt 25:46

שָׁפַט

shaphat `H8199`

To judge, govern, vindicate; participle shophet, 'judge.'

Hebrew · Ezek 34:17; Judg 2:16

◆ Factbook: Judgment

יָשַׁע

yasha' `H3467`

To save, deliver.

Hebrew · Judg 2:16

עַתּוּד

attud `H6260`

Male goat, he-goat.

Hebrew · Ezek 34:17

10

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

Sheep and goats

Commentators note that shepherds often grazed mixed flocks by day and separated them at night, since goats need more warmth. Sheep were generally more valuable.

Right and left

The right hand was the place of honor and favor (Psalm 110:1), so placing the sheep on the right signals blessing.

Hospitality

In the ancient Near East, receiving travelers with food and shelter was a sacred duty (Genesis 18:1-8). Itinerant teachers and missionaries depended on it (Matthew 10:11).

SOURCED **Early witnesses**

> *"Why, for this reason they are brethren, because they are lowly, because they are poor, because they are outcast.*

John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 79, on 25:31-46. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

> *For further back also He says, that they who receive not such as these shall suffer more grievous things than Sodom; and here He says, Inasmuch as you did it not unto one of the least of these my brethren, you did it not unto me.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 79, on 25:45. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

DEBATED

Where scholars differ

Who are 'the least of these'?

The video, like many interpreters, reads them as Jesus' disciples and missionaries. Chrysostom calls them brethren 'because they are lowly, because they are poor,' and many read the phrase as anyone in need.

AD 70 or the final judgment?

The video ties the passage to the judgment on Jerusalem in AD 70. Most interpreters read 25:31-46 as the final judgment of all nations at Christ's return.

Saved by deeds?

Some ask whether this teaches salvation by works. Many answer that the deeds reveal who belongs to the King, as fruit reveals a tree (7:16-20).

CAREFUL READING

Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- 2 Kings 17 tells of Assyria taking Samaria; Babylon's campaign against Jerusalem is 2 Kings 24-25 (with 2 Chronicles 36).
- Gideon's call is Judges 6:11-14; Judges 6:8 is the unnamed prophet sent before him.
- The ninety-nine and the one lost sheep are in Matthew 18:12-14; 18:10 is the warning not to despise the little ones.
- The passage says 'I was in prison, and you came to Me' (25:36): visiting, rather than freeing.
- The video's '24:25' means chapters 24 and 25 together; the captions also garble the names Othniel and Ehud.

II · BACKGROUND

From the judges to Chrysostom

Coral dots mark what Matthew 25:31-46 echoes or this episode covers. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

c. 1200 BC DEBATED
Yahweh raises up judges who save
Judges 2:16

722 BC
Assyria takes Samaria
2 Kings 17:6

586 BC
Babylon burns the temple
2 Kings 25:9

c. 585 BC DEBATED
Ezekiel: God judges between sheep and goats
Ezekiel 34:17 *Echoed: 25:32*

c. AD 30 DEBATED
The sheep and the goats
Matthew 25:31-46 *This episode*

AD 70
Rome destroys the temple
Matthew 24:2

c. AD 390
Chrysostom: brethren because they are lowly
Matthew 25:40

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Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Hebrews 13:2
Do not neglect hospitality to strangers
ADDED

Matthew 10:40
Whoever receives you receives Me
ADDED

John 10:11-16
The good shepherd
ADDED

James 2:14-17
Faith without works
ADDED

Revelation 20:11-15
The great white throne
ADDED

13

Reflection and discussion

0 of 6 questions marked done on this device.

1. ☐ How does Jesus' earlier teaching shape 'the least of these My brothers'?
2. ☐ Why were the righteous surprised that they had served the King?
3. ☐ What does Ezekiel 34 add to the picture of sheep and goats?
4. ☐ How can judgment be both destruction and salvation?
5. ☐ Where are the 'lost sheep among the goats' in your circles of influence?
6. ☐ How do your words and your lifestyle together show the gospel?

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Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The lesson: when Jesus comes in His glory, He expects to find His disciples among the lost, proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom of heaven with both their words and their lifestyles. Words shaped by the gospel save souls; a lifestyle shaped by the gospel cares for those in need. The sheep do not separate from the goats; they go find other lost sheep among them. Ask: at church, at work and at home, is Jesus seeing me obey what He taught His disciples in Matthew 25?

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

pick one item from 25:35-36 (food, drink, welcome, clothing, a visit) and do it this week for someone who serves Christ, along with a word about Him.

> *"When Jesus comes in his glory, he expects to find his disciples among the lost proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom of heaven with both their words and their lifestyles.*
>
> From the video

15

Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ Judgment ◆ Dove ◆ Kingdom of heaven ◆ Angel ◆ Serpent ◆ Temple (Jewish) ◆ Jerusalem ◆ Book of Psalms ◆ John Chrysostom ◆ Disciples ◆ Ezekiel (prophet) ◆ Gideon ◆ Gospel ◆ Healing ◆ Hypocrite ◆ Valley of Hinnom ◆ Widow ◆ Daniel (the prophet) ◆ False prophet ◆ Priest ◆ Son of Man ◆ Wolf ◆ Babylon ◆ Remnant ◆ Shepherd ◆ Sodom and Gomorrah ◆ Assyria ◆ Passover ◆ Weeds (tares, darnel) ◆ Wheat ◆ Church ◆ Eternal life ◆ Parable of the lost sheep ◆ Bethany (Mount of Olives) ◆ Mount of Olives ◆ Deborah ◆ Ehud ◆ Hospitality ◆ Last Judgment ◆ Midianites ◆ Othniel ◆ Samson ◆ Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego ◆ Parable of the sheep and goats

Source: the video's auto-generated YouTube captions, read in full. Scripture quotations are from the Legacy Standard Bible, copyright 2021 by The Lockman Foundation. All rights reserved. Chrysostom: Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (public domain). Images: Wikimedia Commons (Sant'Apollinare Nuovo mosaic; Fra Angelico; public domain). Map: drawn for this study.

Offline copy. Live page: https://shea-nelson.github.io/workout-app/bible/matthew-49/